

Generative engine optimization (GEO) is the practice of structuring digital content and managing online presence to improve visibility in responses generated by generative artificial intelligence (AI) systems. The practice influences the way large language models (LLMs) retrieve, summarize, and present information in response to user queries. Related terms include answer engine optimization (AEO) and artificial intelligence optimization (AIO).

The concept of GEO first appeared in response to generative AI technologies being integrated into mainstream search and information retrieval systems.

Terminology

Several overlapping terms describe related practices, and usage varies across practitioners, vendors, and publications. No consensus definition distinguishing these terms had been established in the academic literature as of early 2026, and the terms are frequently used interchangeably in trade and practitioner contexts. Other terms for the same concept include answer engine optimization (AEO), large language model optimization (LLMO), artificial intelligence optimization (AIO), and AI SEO.

In 2026, Google released documentation titled "Optimizing your website for generative AI features on Google Search." According to this documentation, "optimizing for generative AI search is optimizing for the search experience, and thus still SEO." This position had previously been shared at conferences, with 2026 being the first time Google released official documentation stating it.

Writing for Forrester Research, Nikhil Lai argued in 2025 that answer engine optimization (and related terms) are "significantly, but not fundamentally, different from SEO" and that advocates of terms like AEO, GEO, AIO, and LLMO "tend to exaggerate SEO and AEO's differences to carve a startup-sized hole in marketers' tech stacks."

Factors influencing generative engine optimization

By early 2026, the focus of GEO practitioners shifted from simple keyword placement to "semantic relevance", a metric driven by the integration of advertising into conversational AI. OpenAI and Google began monetizing AI search results, which is not currently considered an aspect of generative engine optimization but is adjacent.

Tools

Various tools are used to monitor how websites and brands are cited, referenced, or incorporated into responses produced by large language models. This includes free tools like the AI Performance report in Bing Webmaster Tools and Search Generative AI performance reports in Google Search Console.

See also

Information retrieval

Retrieval-augmented generation

Search engine optimization

== References ==